

FIRST CONGREGATIONAL CHURCH
of Los Angeles

Lent 1

The Only Thing More Powerful Than Hate is Love

Here is a River

22 February 2026



Photo by Renée Darline Roden '14, '18 M.T.S.

540 S. Commonwealth Avenue, Los Angeles, California 90020
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The Gathering of the People

First Congregational Church of Los Angeles is a safe place for all people, and we celebrate our diversity of race, creed, age, ability, gender, religion, cultural background, sexual orientation, gender identities and expressions... We extend a warm welcome to all this morning and especially those who are with us for the first time. Your presence both enriches us and this time of celebration together ~

Please note that our services are live streamed at fccla.org/live.

Organ Prelude Concert

Agatha Teague, Guest Organist

Praeludium in E Minor, "Little" Nicolaus Bruhns (1665-1697)
Erbarm dich mein, o Herre Gott, BWV 721 - J.S. Bach (1685-1750)
Canzona - Sperindio Bertoldo (1530-1570)
Organ Sonata in G Major, Op 28: Allegretto - Edward Elgar (1857-1934)
Rubrics IV: The Peace May Be Exchanged - Dan Locklair (b. 1949)
Cortege et Litanie - Marcel Dupre (1886-1971)

Chiming of the Hour

Welcome

Rev. Michael Lehman

Words of Gathering

Rev. Lehman, Greta Langenberg & Danielle Vigent

Holy One, as we gather each week,
we give thanks for the opportunity
to see the world through your eyes
and know once again,
that we are always and forever
held by your love.

When the sun shines,
and when the rain falls,
we are held by your love.

When the money gods smile upon us,
and when the bottom falls out of the market,
we are held by your love.

When family is the wind beneath our wings,
and when it is a hurricane of hurt,
we are held by your love.

When we are strong in body and mind,
and when illness reveals our vulnerability,
we are held by your love.

When the beauty of creation drops us to our knees in awe,
and when the injustice of humanity drops us to
our knees in prayer,
we are held by your love.

For we, O God, are in you,
and you are in us,
and there is a country of the soul
where the eternal joy of Being
sustains us on the rocky road of becoming.

*This morning, Holy One,
we give thanks for your
never ending love
as we gather in this time
that is holy.*

May it forever be so.
May it forever be so, for all of us!

Please stand now, in body or in spirit, for our Hymn of Gathering

***Hymn of Gathering**

Love Now Ascending

NICAEA

Holy, holy, holy, love now ascending
Early in the morning our song shall rise to you.
Holy, holy, holy, joy that has no ending
Giving, forgiving, breathing life anew.

Holy, holy, holy, love without a limit
Care that binds creation in sacred unity,
Holy, holy, holy, birthing every minute,
Christ, Love's revealer, sets our spirits free.

Holy, holy, holy, infinite compassion,
Makes a place for every soul in God's eternal reign,
Holy, holy, holy, truth beyond religion,
Love that endures should nothing else remain.

Holy, holy, holy, raise your voice in singing,
Join the cosmic chorus in praise of Love divine,
Holy, holy, holy, God beyond all naming,
Echoes our song in harmony sublime. [JBurklo]

***Prayer of Awareness**

Rev. Lehman

All things come from you, O God,
and to you we return.
All things emerge in your great river of life
and into you we vanish again.
At the beginning of this day
we wake
not as separate streams
but as countless currents in a single flow

the flow of this day's dawning
the flow of this day's delight
the flow of this day's sorrows
your flow, O God,
in the twistings and turnings of our days.
[jphilipnewell]

May it be so.
May it be so for all of us!
Amen and Amen.

***Introit**

"Love Is Little"
Cathedral Choir

arr. DAVID GARCÍA SALDAÑA

***The Lord's Prayer for Lent**

Danielle Vigent

The 'Abba' Prayer

You are invited to pray in the spirit of the Lord's Prayer, and in your original language, as appropriate

*Loving Presence, luminous in all creation,
hallowed be your name.
Thy kin-dom come.
May we reflect on earth
the yielding perfection of the heavens.*

*Help us to receive an illumed measure from the earth this day.
Forgive us when we trespass against others,
human and other than human,
as we forgive others who trespass against us.*

*Keep us on the path of wisdom
when we are tempted to take the selfish path.
May it be your rule we follow,
your power we exercise,
and your radiance that allures.*

*May this be the truth that guides our lives,
the ground from which our future will grow,
until we meet again.*
Amen and Amen! (BSanguin/dddc)

***Gloria Deo**

Glory be to God, and to the Christ and to the Holy Ghost,
As it was in the beginning, is now and ever shall be.
World without end, Amen, Amen.

***Passing of the Peace**

Rev. Lehman

With gratitude we have gathered in this place of peace, once again.
In this time together, may we continue to create here a circle of love,
ever expanding,
ever growing.

A place of wisdom.
A place of connection.
A place of hope.

This morning, may the Peace and Love of God be with you.
And also with you!

You are invited to share this ancient greeting with a bow

Please be seated

Celebration of Baptism ~ Sabrina Tyas

Reading from Our Religious Tradition
from the Gospel of Matthew

Greta Langenberg & Danielle Vigent

This is the Gospel of Love and Grace.
Thanks be to God!

Prayers with the People

Rev. Lehman

Invitation to Silence and Prayer

Amid all the noise in our lives, we take this moment to sit in silence:
to give thanks for another day;
to give thanks for all those in our lives
who have brought us warmth and love;
to give thanks for the gift of life.

(Silence)

In this time of silence,
let us open ourselves to the process of becoming more whole:
of living more fully;
of understanding more completely
the meaning of our lives here on this earth. (Adapt.THaley)

(Silence)

We gather grateful for the companionship
of hearts and minds
seeking to speak the truth in love.

We gather grateful for our heritage,
for all those who came before us,
whose prophetic words and deeds
make possible our dreams and our insight
And we gather grateful for the gift of life itself,
mindful that to respect life means both
to celebrate what life is
and to insist on what it can become

[Adapt.MSMilner]

Let us now be in silence, together.

Silence

Prayer of Our Hearts

Beloved One,
You created us in your image,
breathing into our lives, your divine love.

Equipped for healing,
you make us capable of right-ing relationships.
In history. With each other. To the planet. For our futures.
You wove courage into our bones,
and a longing to walk in this word, together.
We can feel this gift when we are in-touch with life:
because we need each other.

Make all that would betray this Sacred connection –
the everyday and the ordinary practices,
and the rising terror of evil's gains –
be exposed for what they are.

*Strengthen us to persevere in these times,
as we learn that the only thing in this world
that is more powerful than hate, is love.*

In these days, help us to be brave enough
to search our hearts,
as we separate truth from falsehood.
Walk with us as we work to clear a way
through all that dismantles life and love.
Help us to be wise as we turn away from
all that confines us and be with us as we
walk onto the paths of freedom.

*May our labors toward liberation be fruitful.
May we mean what we pray.
May we be compelled by dreams of collective transformation
to rise to the moment and to remain committed,
to the work that is ours to do.*

*May our commitment to Love
rise above all others,
so that we will no longer tolerate
our complicity with all that damages and destroys.*

Made in your image, Holy One,
we are made capable
of abolishing what is evil
as we work to build a better world, together. [adapt/enfleshed]

Make it so among us.
Make it so around us.
Make it so within us.
Amen and Amen!

Meditation Anthem

"God's Got The Whole World"
Cathedral Choir

MARK A. MILLER

Sermon

Here is a River

Rev. Laura Vail Fregin

The Eucharist and Blessings

Rev. Fregin & Rev. Lehman

Words of Invitation and Remembrance

With our eyes wide open, we come to this table
knowing the realities of our world.
We live in a time and place
where words are honed to have painful edges,
where fear too often reigns,
and shards of broken trust are used as weapons,
rending into tatters relationships once built on love.

And yet, in this too-fragile world,
we look for ways to strengthen love
in all our relationships,
to live in ways that lift each other's souls,
and build, for every single human being,
a place that we might all know
the beauty of being celebrated for who they are.

*At this table we break bread, share stories, build new and
hope-filled memories as we let go of the hurts and heartaches
of other times and other tables.*

At this table we fill ourselves up with the things of love
that we might live strong and confident
in the places we hold in this world.

*As those who hold a vision of a love-filled world,
we break this bread as Jesus did,
and we eat together knowing it is the bread of new life.*

We also pour and share a cup as Jesus did,
because we want others to come and drink
this cup of hope along with us.

Sharing of the Bread and the Cup

At this table we celebrate all the diverse ways we have been created. Everyone is invited to share in this feast. This morning we will receive communion with gluten free wafers and grape juice. You are invited to come forward to receive these gifts and then light a candle to signify the prayers of your heart on this day. As we share this time, we remember that this is the bread of new life and the cup of hope, given in love for each of us.

Invitation to Generosity

Danielle Vigent

At First Church, we consider every pledge, tithe, offering and contribution a gift for the life of our community of faith. No matter how they're given, our gifts show gratitude. You are invited to visit our website at fccla.org/give. Our hospitality team will also bring baskets for your in-person gifts during the Offertory.

Offertory

"All My Trials"

Frank Hobbs, Molly Pease, & Scott Graff, Trio

NEGRO SPIRITUAL arr. MILTON OKUN,

PETER YARROW, & PAUL STOOKEY

*Lenten Doxology

Praise God from whom all blessings flow.

Praise God, all creatures here below.

Praise God above ye heavenly hosts.

Creator, Christ, and Holy Ghost.

*Offering Prayer

Danielle Vigent

Gracious One,

On this day, we found ourselves once again,

longing to reach out and touch the sky,

and to be in a place

where we could be reminded of your love.

On this day, we wanted to offer our tears
and ask they be held deep within the heart of life,
knowing they represent the struggles
we all still endure.

On this day, we needed to be embraced
by loving arms telling us again and again,
that in this place, we are all welcome.

We give thanks, Holy One,
for the love and assurance we have been given
in this time together.
Help us now as we leave this place of amazing love,
to open our eyes to all that is around us
and truly see with the eyes of our hearts,
those who desperately need your love, and our love.

For this and so much more,
we ask, and we give thanks, O God.
Amen and Amen!

Please be seated

Life at First Church

Rev. Fregin & Rev. Lehman

Words of Blessing

Rev. Fregin

Here on the river I have known peace and beauty
such as I never knew in any other place.
There is always work here that I need to be doing
and I have so many worries, for life on the edge
seems always threatening to go over the edge.

But I am always surprised, when I look back on times
here that I know to have been laborious or worrisome or sad,
to discover that they were never out of the presence of peace
and beauty, for here I have always been in the world itself.

-Wendell Berry

Amen! May it be so!

Choral Response

"Give Me Your Hand"
Cathedral Choir

NATHANIEL DETT

*Hymn for the Journey

Love Astounding

HOLY MANNA

Love astounding, Love confounding limits fearful minds impose.
Love renewing, Love pursuing every heart until it knows
Love's transforming, healing goodness, Love's abiding gentle grace.
Love's endurance, Love's assurance, Love's consoling strong embrace.

Love receiving, Love Believing, we rejoice with thanks and song,
Faith regaining, hope proclaiming; Love has taught us, we belong
Safe within Love's tender keeping, safe from fear's persistent call.
Love's defending, Love unending, Love of God enfolding all.

Postlude

Agatha Teague, Guest *Organist*

No. II: from Four Sketches for Pedal Piano - Robert Schumann (1810-1856)

Inside The Music

"All My Trials" has been a favorite Spiritual of mine since I first heard Peter, Paul, and Mary, and subsequently Harry Belafonte, sing it on their respective albums. I was a teen in the 1980s by then, and the impact still landed. It's been recorded so many times by artists with wide audiences, that it's in people's ear even if they might not be aware of it. The origins of the piece often point to the Bahamas. Though no ethnomusicological sources can confirm this, it became the origin story in the 1960s. It first appeared in the middle of the Roots Revival of the 1940s-1960s. During this time in American musical history a ground swell of itinerant performers and audiences gathered around the sharing of music from varied folk traditions blended with their own. Messages of justice, kindness, and understanding filled their spaces. It makes sense, then, that Peter, Paul, and Mary chose for their opening verse the lyrics "I had a little book was given to me, and every page spelled liberty." America during the Roots Revival was turning over on itself. People across the nation were eager to find new answers to old systems, and other people were eager to keep up the status quo. The quiet insistence of a book that speaks to liberty has a persistent weight. Another verse that has always stood out to me is "If religion were a thing that money could buy, the rich would live and the poor would die." It's a reminder that financial inequality has been a feature of almost every system humanity has created. And, every human society has had people devoted to equity. The chorus "Too late my brother, too late but nevermind, all my trials soon be over" also stands out to me. It's ominous and immediate. What is too late? The feeling

that we can inspire change? The life of an individual? Are the trials corporeal or spiritual? That moment is accompanied by a Roots Revival favorite chord change of the 4 chord to the minor 4 chord. The half step drop at the center of this chord exchange seems to weep and electrify simultaneously. It's a progression that always feels unexpected. This is a song that gets under your skin and wrestles, but won't let go. It continues to ask what it is that we're missing as it encourages us to deepen into our faith, and reach out to our neighbors. I feel indebted to the open hearts of the Roots Revivalists for seeking out music from different places. Because of them, I got to know music intimately that I wouldn't have had access to otherwise. Singing music from different cultures brings us closer to hearing each other. That's a significant gift. As I was singing "All My Trials" to my kids this week and knowing that they will now get to have it to help them in life, I realized how special arts communities are, and how their impact continues to stir and shape our world." ~ Dr. David Harris

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